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ACADEMIC VAULT

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THA 242: Costume and Appearance Design - Stage, Screen and Carnival

Dress a character with intention, from festival spectacle to film close-up

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 200L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

Costume is character information made visible. This pack covers research and period sources, colour and silhouette, fabric behaviour under stage light and camera, make-up for stage versus screen, and the workflow from sketch to fitting to wardrobe maintenance.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Research and document a period or cultural costume source responsibly.
- Design costumes that communicate character, status and period.
- Distinguish stage make-up from screen make-up technique.
- Manage a wardrobe plot, fittings and maintenance for a production.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Research and concept

Design begins with evidence, not mood boards alone.

- Identify the period, region, class and occasion of the production.
- Collect primary sources: photographs, museum catalogues, archival images.
- Note what a fabric, dye or accessory would actually have been available.
- Avoid mixing culturally distinct dress traditions into a generic 'African' look.
- Write a concept statement linking costume choices to character and theme.
- Credit your sources in a design file.

> **Specific, not decorative**
> A faded collar tells the audience about money. A random bright scarf tells them nothing.

Colour, silhouette and light

Costume must read from the back row and survive a close-up.

- Silhouette communicates status and period before detail is visible.
- Colour reads differently under tungsten, LED and daylight.
- Pattern can vibrate on camera; test on screen before approval.
- Fabric weight affects movement, heat and sound.
- Contrast separates a character from the set; blending creates anonymity.
- Test make-up under the actual lighting plot, not a bathroom mirror.

Workflow and wardrobe

A costume department is logistics as much as art.

- Costume plot: every character, scene and change listed in a table.
- Measurements, fittings and alteration schedules.
- Budget per character and per scene; track receipts.
- Quick-change plans and dressers for fast transitions.
- Maintenance: cleaning, repairs, labelling and storage.
- Returns, hires and security of borrowed items.

Costume is character before speech

A costume tells the audience who a person is, what they do, where they are and what has just happened to them - and it does so before a single line. That is why costume design begins with questions about the character, not with sketches: age, occupation, income, climate, period, social position, and the precise moment of the story.

The design brief is written, not imagined. For each character you need: the silhouette (the overall shape), the palette (colours and their relationships), the texture and weight of fabric, the condition of the garments, and the changes required by the action. A character who has been travelling needs creases and dust; a character who has just been humiliated needs a garment that no longer fits the way it did.

Students lose marks by designing "beautiful clothes" rather than characters. A test: show your sketch to someone who has not read the play and ask what they can tell about the person. If they can only say "she looks nice", the design has not done its job.

Designing for the medium